Existentialism Study Guide

Freedom, responsibility, authenticity and the absurd

Use this guide to: get the big picture fast, learn the key terms with everyday examples, choose what to read first, and test yourself. Full articles are at libraryofphilosophy.com/existentialism.html.

1. Existentialism at a glance

Fact	Detail
What it is	A philosophical movement about concrete human existence: freedom, choice, responsibility, anxiety, death and the search for meaning
Roots	19th-century thinkers Søren Kierkegaard and Friedrich Nietzsche; the label became widespread in France in the 1940s
Core slogan	"Existence precedes essence" (Jean-Paul Sartre): we exist first, then define ourselves through our choices
Main thinkers	Kierkegaard, Nietzsche, Heidegger, Jaspers, Marcel, Sartre, Beauvoir, Camus, Merleau-Ponty
Two broad strands	Religious (Kierkegaard, Marcel) and atheistic (Sartre, Beauvoir); Nietzsche and Camus are often grouped in, though Camus rejected the label
Key themes	Freedom, responsibility, anxiety, authenticity, bad faith, the absurd, death, other people
Best known for	Radical freedom, authenticity, the absurd, and the claim that meaning is made rather than given
Start reading with	Sartre, *Existentialism Is a Humanism*, or Camus, *The Myth of Sisyphus*

2. The big idea in 60 words

Existentialists start from the fact that we exist before anyone tells us what we are for. No fixed human nature, God-given plan or social role settles who we must be. We are free, and so responsible for our choices. That freedom brings anxiety, but also the chance to live authentically, face death honestly and create meaning ourselves, alongside other people.

3. Three phases of existentialism

Scholars often group the thinkers into three overlapping waves. This is a helpful simplification, not a strict rule.

Phase	Core focus	Key figures and works	Key concepts
Precursors (19th century)	Individual existence against abstract systems and mass conformity	Kierkegaard, *Fear and Trembling*, *The Concept of Anxiety*; Nietzsche, *The Gay Science*; Dostoevsky, *Notes from Underground*	Subjective truth, leap of faith, anxiety, creating values
Phenomenological wave (1920s–30s)	The structure of human existence as lived	Heidegger, *Being and Time* (1927); Jaspers; Marcel	Dasein, thrownness, being-toward-death, authenticity
French wave (1940s–50s)	Freedom, ethics and politics after the Second World War	Sartre, *Being and Nothingness*; Beauvoir, *The Ethics of Ambiguity*; Camus, *The Myth of Sisyphus*; Merleau-Ponty	Radical freedom, bad faith, ambiguity, the absurd, revolt

4. Key terms with everyday examples

Term	Plain-English meaning	Everyday example
Existence precedes essence	A knife has its purpose defined before it is made. Humans exist first and define themselves through what they do.	You are not "born to be" a particular career; you become who you are through choices.
Freedom	We can always choose how to act and respond, even when we cannot choose our circumstances.	You cannot choose to be laid off, but you can choose how you respond.
Responsibility	Owning our choices and their consequences without blaming fate or "human nature."	Saying "I chose to" instead of "I had to."
Anxiety (angst)	The dizzying awareness of open possibilities and of our own freedom (Kierkegaard, Heidegger, Sartre).	Dread before a major life decision with no guaranteed answer.
Facticity	The givens of our life that we did not choose: body, past, language, society, death.	Where you were born and the language you grew up speaking.
Transcendence	Our ability to go beyond what we are now by projecting ourselves toward possibilities.	Deciding to retrain for a new career.
Bad faith (*mauvaise foi*)	Self-deception that denies our freedom by treating ourselves as fixed things or role-bound objects (Sartre).	"I'm just a shy person, so I can't speak up."
Authenticity	Living in a way that owns our freedom and choices, instead of drifting with the crowd.	Choosing a path from your own values, not only from expectations.
The Absurd	The clash between our hunger for meaning and a silent, indifferent universe (Camus).	Wondering what it is all for while doing a repetitive task.
Revolt	Camus's response to the absurd: live fully, refusing both despair and false hope.	Continuing to care for people and work despite uncertainty.
Dasein	Heidegger's term ("being-there") for the kind of being that questions its own existence.	Asking "what is my life for?" shows you are not a mere object.
Thrownness	We find ourselves "thrown" into a world, time and family we did not choose (Heidegger).	Realising your values were shaped long before you could weigh them.
Being-toward-death	Awareness of our own mortality shapes how we live (Heidegger).	A health scare prompting you to rethink your priorities.
Leap of faith	Commitment beyond rational proof, especially religious faith (Kierkegaard).	Committing to a vocation or relationship without guarantees.
The look (the Other)	Being seen by another makes us aware of ourselves as an object (Sartre).	Feeling suddenly self-conscious when someone watches you.
Ambiguity	We are both free subjects and limited bodies in a social world (Beauvoir).	Feeling free to choose yet shaped by class, gender or history.

5. Facticity and transcendence in one picture

For Sartre and Beauvoir, every human life has two sides. Facticity is everything given to us: our body, past, society and mortality. Transcendence is our freedom to go beyond those givens by choosing projects and values. Denying the first is fantasy; denying the second is bad faith. Authentic living holds both together, which Beauvoir calls ambiguity.

FACTICITY

What is given to us

- Our body and health
- Our past and upbringing
- Our time, place and class
- Other people's expectations
- Our mortality

Your situation
= both together

TRANSCENDENCE

What we make of it

- Our choices and projects
- Our values and commitments
- How we interpret our past
- Who we aim to become
- How we treat others

6. Timeline

Year	Event
1813	Kierkegaard born in Copenhagen
1843–44	Kierkegaard writes *Fear and Trembling* and *The Concept of Anxiety*
1882	Nietzsche, *The Gay Science* (“God is dead”)
1927	Heidegger publishes *Being and Time*
1938	Sartre’s novel *Nausea*
1942	Camus publishes *The Stranger* and *The Myth of Sisyphus*
1943	Sartre publishes *Being and Nothingness*
1945	Sartre’s lecture “Existentialism Is a Humanism” (published 1946)
1947	Beauvoir, *The Ethics of Ambiguity*
1949	Beauvoir, *The Second Sex*
1951	Camus, *The Rebel*
1960	Camus dies; Sartre publishes *Critique of Dialectical Reason*
1980 / 1986	Sartre dies (1980); Beauvoir dies (1986)
2016	Sarah Bakewell’s *At the Existentialist Café* brings the movement to new readers

7. Where to start reading

Order	Book	Why read it	Difficulty
1	Sartre, *Existentialism Is a Humanism*	A short, clear lecture setting out freedom, responsibility and anguish.	Easy to moderate
2	Camus, *The Stranger* or *The Myth of Sisyphus*	A novel and an essay on the absurd and how to live with it.	Easy to moderate
3	Bakewell, *At the Existentialist Café*	A lively group portrait of the thinkers and their ideas.	Easy
4	Beauvoir, *The Ethics of Ambiguity*	Existentialist ethics: our freedom is tied to others' freedom.	Moderate
5	Kierkegaard, *Fear and Trembling* or *The Sickness unto Death*	Faith, anxiety and the self; the origin of the tradition.	Moderate to hard
6	Nietzsche, *Thus Spoke Zarathustra* or *The Gay Science*	Creating values after the loss of old certainties.	Moderate
7	Heidegger, *Being and Time*; Sartre, *Being and Nothingness*	The major technical works behind the movement.	Hard

8. Common misconceptions

- **"Existentialism is just gloomy or nihilist."** Existentialists stress freedom, responsibility and the creation of meaning. Camus explicitly rejected nihilism.
- **"All existentialists deny God."** Kierkegaard and Marcel were Christian thinkers; Sartre and Beauvoir were atheists.
- **"Everyone on the list accepted the label."** Heidegger and Camus both rejected being called existentialists.
- **"Radical freedom means anything goes."** Sartre argued that choosing for ourselves also commits us to an image of humanity, which brings heavy responsibility.
- **"It is only about isolated individuals."** Beauvoir and others stress other people, society and the concrete situation in which freedom is exercised.

9. Main criticisms

Marxist critics such as Georg Lukács attacked existentialism as an individualist retreat from social struggle, and Sartre later tried to join existentialism with Marxism. Rudolf Carnap mocked Heidegger's talk of "the Nothing" as meaningless. Others argue that radical freedom underestimates social and psychological constraints, a point Beauvoir's emphasis on situation tries to answer. Heidegger's membership of the Nazi Party in 1933 raises hard questions about the link between his philosophy and his politics. Defenders reply that existentialism is a demanding ethic of responsibility, not a licence for self-indulgence.

10. Test yourself

- In your own words, what does “existence precedes essence” mean? Give one example.
- What is bad faith, and how does it differ from honest acceptance of your circumstances?
- Explain facticity and transcendence, and why Sartre and Beauvoir need both.
- Why does anxiety (angst) matter to Kierkegaard and Heidegger?
- What is the absurd for Camus, and how does revolt respond to it?
- How does Beauvoir connect my freedom to the freedom of others?
- Why is it misleading to say that existentialists are all atheists or all pessimists?
- Choose a real choice you face and analyse it with one existentialist concept.

Answer hints

1. Humans have no fixed purpose in advance; we define ourselves through choices, unlike a tool made for a purpose. 2. Bad faith denies our freedom (treating ourselves as fixed things or roles); honest acceptance admits our limits while owning our choices. 3. Facticity is what is given; transcendence is our freedom to go beyond it; denying either distorts reality. 4. Anxiety discloses our freedom, finitude and responsibility. 5. The absurd is the clash between our need for meaning and a silent universe; revolt means living fully without false hope or despair. 6. Willing my own freedom requires willing the freedom of others, since freedom grows through others’ freedom. 7. Kierkegaard was a Christian, and many existentialists stress creating meaning. 8. Answers vary; ground them in a named concept such as authenticity, bad faith or responsibility.

Sources and further reading

- Sartre, J.-P. *Existentialism Is a Humanism* (lecture 1945; published 1946).
- Camus, A. *The Myth of Sisyphus* (1942).
- Beauvoir, S. de. *The Ethics of Ambiguity* (1947).
- Bakewell, S. *At the Existentialist Café: Freedom, Being, and Apricot Cocktails* (2016).
- Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy, “Existentialism”: plato.stanford.edu/entries/existentialism/
- Internet Encyclopedia of Philosophy, “Existentialism”: iep.utm.edu/existent/

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